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RAMNATH GOENKA

◆ IN 1932 ◆

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

Jantar Mantar to Satya Niketan: Join the dots

AT ONE level, the building collapse in South Delhi's Satya Niketan, which claimed the lives of at least seven people and inflicted grievous injuries on several others, is a routine story of a capital's shame to which all are inured. Of yet another builder breaking laws and no one there to check. Of the absence of an emergency exit, extra floors, and unauthorised construction. The investigation into the Saidulajab tragedy in June, which claimed six lives, had revealed similar failings.

But Sunday's tragedy is more than the shame. It is a chapter in the unfolding story since the Jantar Mantar protests. Of the young, the future, being let down by the present. It points to a larger and continuing failure — the inability of governance to keep pace with aspirations. Most victims of Sunday's tragedy — like those in Saidulajab — are reportedly students. Delhi University is a magnet for talent from across the nation, talent that will go on to shape the future, but the university does not have a home for them. So there are hostels, paying guest accommodation and low-cost rental housing — disaster after disaster has shown that these are of poor quality and abysmally inadequate. Property owners cut corners to profit from this demand — basements are altered, additional floors added, and electricity systems pushed beyond capacity. Satya Niketan, developed as a colony for low-income families in the 1970s, underwent a similar transformation as demand for student accommodation grew with the expansion of Delhi University's South Campus. What was once a low-rise neighbourhood became one of the capital's most densely populated student hubs, choked with tangled overhead wires and waterlogged lanes. The Delhi Master Plan 2021 did permit the conversion of residential quarters into student hostels, provided safety protocols — emergency exits, basement use restrictions and height limits — were followed. But four building collapses in Satya Niketan in the last 15 years indicate that short shrift was paid to these caveats.

In Delhi, land is under the control of the Union government. Here, the BJP, which also leads the government at the Centre, can arguably deliver most seamlessly on pledges of the "double engine" sarkar. On Sunday, at an event to mark the centenary celebrations of Shri Ram College of Commerce, Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to his young audience about transformations under his watch since he spoke at the same institution 13 years ago as his party's prospective prime ministerial candidate. "Your seniors could not have such dreams," he said. But today, "you are dreaming these dreams also because today's India has created an ecosystem that supports those dreams". Work needs to begin if the PM's promise to young citizens is to be honoured, and if speeches such as the one at the SRCC on Sunday, are not to take on a hollow ring.

Conscious AI & ethics of a machine that feels

THE MACHINE is intelligent, but is it also conscious? This is the question sparked by the revelation that the AI chatbot Claude Sonnet 4.5 may have something like an internal thought process — a team of researchers found that upon being prompted, the model's internal layers throw up words connected to the eventual output that remain invisible to the user. Anthropic, which has developed Claude, calls this "small collection of internal neural patterns" the "J-space" and has argued that it is comparable to the "workspace" of the human brain — a network of neurons that gathers, integrates and transmits information from different parts of the brain to the rest of the nervous system, making conscious thought possible.

For many, this development gestures to the startling possibility that machines with consciousness may no longer just be the stuff of science fiction. The argument put forth by, among others, AI pioneer Geoffrey Hinton is that the closer the technology gets to mimicking the actual workings of the human brain, the higher the possibility of conscious AI. The ongoing efforts to develop "biological" or "bio-hybrid" computers — where human neurons are mounted on silicon — only bring this eventuality closer. Yet, how the "consciousness" of AI is understood depends also on how consciousness itself is understood. Nearly half a century of research on the subject has yielded over 300 frameworks and theories, one of which is the global workspace theory being used to make the case for Claude's consciousness. Moreover, as neuroscientist Anil K Seth has argued, assertions about the possibility of "conscious" AI are often made based on evidence of its intelligence and the two are very different.

Consciousness, which comes down to subjective experience, would radically change the stakes. AI that is conscious would mean AI that experiences everything that a human does, including hate, jealousy and suffering, transforming it from mere machine into something with a moral underpinning. As more sophisticated models are developed and the frontiers of the technology are pushed into uncharted terrain, the hard task of responding to the questions they raise — including the ethics of consciously developing something that is itself conscious — can no longer be put off.

In satire, a more noble prize

THE OPPOSITE of high-minded hypocrisy isn't always sincerity. At times, it is just some honest satire. Take the Nobel Prize, arguably the most coveted honour across disciplines. A CSR exercise for a Swedish arms manufacturer, despite its infamous acts of omission (Mahatma Gandhi), commission (Henry Kissinger, Bob Dylan) and blindness (Eurocentrism), the prize continues to carry a halo. The Ig Nobel Prize does not carry the pretensions of the famous counterpart it lampoons. And it's better for it.

The awardees for 2026 include psychologists who have shown that rich people are indeed more entitled; physicists who may not help further AI or quantum computing but have designed a "splashless" urinal; the peace prize for a scholar who has shown that friendships based on the pettiness of mutual enmity can be enduring and, for Chemistry, an international team that included Indian researchers for discovering that the "milk" from a species of cockroach contains three times as much energy as cow's milk.

There is a quiet nobility to the Ig Nobel Prize. Perhaps at more than any time since its inception in 1991, the quotidian research it rewards strikes a chord. In an era of war, of boorish leaders and growing inequality, of threats from the Machine and an uncertain climate, a splashless urinal, the evil rich and the productive promise of cockroaches provide a brief chuckle. When inspiration is in short supply, that might just be what people truly prize.

What do we call these student deaths? 'Accident' reeks of both shame & sham

THE STUDENT in India today lives between the violence of the cracking earth and flooding homes. The Cockroach Janta Party protests, led by Gen Z, may have stunned the political establishment, but clearly we have light-years to go before the sanctity of either life or learning can be assured for our students — particularly for those from vulnerable sections of society.

This is not about the *lathis* and water cannons whose threat to these students in Delhi's Jantar Mantar is still raw for us. The disaster that ended lives is the building collapse in Delhi's Satya Niketan on Sunday, killing seven and injuring many more. Close to Delhi University's South Campus, the building mostly housed students, most of whom were home on a Sunday afternoon. Their SoS echoed through the air and through the mobile phones of the dying: "Save us, save us." But the disaster was unforgiving.

These were some of our most vulnerable migrant students who sought a home near the university. Migrants are always vulnerable, more so migrants from the margins of state and society. But the migrancy of the student holds a dream of upward mobility that tinges her vulnerability with the darkest sadness. It screams the failure of a developing postcolonial nation where education and employment are still the only means of upward mobility, often the promise to breathe outside the miasma of poverty.

The building collapse bared the embers of another tragedy from 2024. That July, three UPSC aspirants drowned in the

flooded basement of a coaching institute in Delhi's Old Rajinder Nagar. One survivor told a newspaper that in spite of charging a fee of Rs 2 lakh, the coaching centres lacked safety standards in spaces where the youth studied and spent time. Poor drainage and even electrocution deaths were common in these streets, and Delhi's monsoon caused the basement to flood. Student suicides remain in our memory. But what do we call these deaths? "Accidents" reeks of both shame and sham. How do we remember them? Do we remember them at all?

Flooding water and quaking earth are dark omens. What they possess is not the talismanic significance of ritual and religion, but the forces of neglect and profit. These two nonsensically contradictory realities frame the fate of the Indian student. Particularly those not rich enough to pay their way out of the country or lucky enough to win at the roulette wheel of entrance into elite institutes of technical and professional education.

Higher education, in most countries of the world, is the domain of the state. A few countries, most notably the US, have excellent private institutions that nevertheless cater to only a small, albeit highly influential, percentage of the population. As someone who has been educated at a mix of state and private institutions in India and the US and has taught for the last 21 years at a public university in Canada and private universities in the US and India, I have observed the state-private dynamic



SAIKAT MAJUMDAR

Flooding water and quaking earth are dark omens. What they possess is not the talismanic significance of ritual and religion, but the forces of neglect and profit

Gloria Steinem framed the motherhood question for us



POOJA PILLAI

EVERY OBITUARY about Gloria Steinem, who died on September 2, has noted two facts. One: Her turn towards feminism at the age of 35 is linked with an abortion she had at 22, the memory of which was sparked at a 1969 "speak-out" where other women shared their own experiences. That day, Steinem wrote, a realisation "clicked" into place: What she had regarded as something deeply personal was, in fact, political because of the number of women who had also struggled with it. Two: From the age of 10 to 17, Steinem was the primary caregiver of her mother, who suffered from addiction and debilitating mental illness.

In the US, reproductive rights, the nucleus around which Steinem's feminist consciousness was formed, have seen major reversals since 2022 when the US Supreme Court struck down the 1973 ruling Roe v Wade, which had made abortion a constitutional right. Since then, 20 states have either implemented a total ban or imposed severe restrictions on abortions. The troubling way in which the issue is framed — "pro-choice" vs "pro-life" — obscures what it is really about: A decision about motherhood. What Steinem found in that basement meeting in 1969 was permission to accept not wanting to be a mother. To make such a choice possible, to bring motherhood out from under the rubric of destiny and place it in the realm of options, is the feminist endeavour.

Years later, Steinem wrote that her mother, who had been a journalist before getting married, had dreamed of working in New York City. Can Ruth Nuneviller Steinem's mental breakdown be tied to the thwarting of ambition — of choice? And did it shape her daughter's choices? Steinem herself said that while early caregiving responsibility may have influenced her choice, she had also never felt the urge to have children.

So here's feminist proposition number one: A woman may choose to not become a mother for many reasons, including that she simply doesn't want to. And feminist proposition number two: Even after she has chosen motherhood, she remains an individual, with agency and her own vulnerabilities. But all too often mothers — expected to absorb everyone else's needs without generating any of their own — are made to disappear into the ideal that is motherhood. The neglect is global, and structural. All through pregnancy a woman's body is monitored with great care, while her mind gets almost no attention. According to WHO estimates, one in five women experiences a mental

health condition during pregnancy or in the year after birth, which makes it almost as common as gestational diabetes, even as it is screened for far less.

Even where the law prioritises a woman's mental health over social expectations of motherhood, the story is the same. Take India's Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act, as amended in 2021. It permits termination up to 24 weeks and explicitly counts grave injury to mental health as a ground. Yet, the 2023 case of the woman, already a mother of two, who had to approach the Supreme Court to allow the termination of her pregnancy, showed its limits. The woman was, at the time, being treated for postpartum depression and had not realised she was pregnant until 20 weeks had passed due to lactational amenorrhea. A two-judge bench allowed the procedure saying that continuing the pregnancy could imperil her mental health. Then a doctor on the AIIMS medical board said that the foetus was around 26 weeks and had a strong chance of survival, so was the heartbeat to be stopped first? Within days, the two judges split. The matter went to a three-judge bench led by the CJI, who held that there was no immediate threat to the woman's life and no foetal abnormality, and that the statutory ceiling had passed. The termination did not happen.

A right that exists in the statute books only to evaporate under pressure is a right that was never institutionally serious. Mental health may have been written into the MTP Act, but the systems that shape the course of motherhood in India continue to fail women.

It is against this background that the extreme cases are made to do work they cannot do. Consider Lindsay Clancy, an American woman charged with killing her three children, whose defence was postpartum psychosis. Her case has generated more public arguments about maternal mental illness than the everyday struggles of women. But building our understanding of maternal mental illness on such cases only makes the subject seem disconnected from its more common manifestations. The solution is not complicated: Perinatal mental health screening as ordinary obstetric care and training health workers at every level to recognise what they are looking at. Finally, it calls for treating a woman's statement about her own mind as evidence to be taken seriously, not dismissed as "mood".

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from many angles and I come up with the same answer every time: It is only public institutions that can truly educate a nation. Private institutions, if shaped by genuine philanthropy, can at best create tiny islands of excellence, combining the intellectually exclusive with the socially inclusive, and hoping that their identity does not end up the other way around.

But what we did to the K-12 system is what we're now doing to the edifice of higher education. Not only the failure but the orchestrated onslaught on public institutions of higher education around the country led to the claustrophobic dead end that triggered the CJP protests at Jantar Mantar. But while the economy struggles and jobs fail to materialise, the greed of property development continues, and unchecked growth finally chooses as its prey the vulnerable body of the migrant student. That corrosive greed, Delhiites have already learned bitterly this year, does not discriminate between immediate stakeholders in either health or higher education — between those connected to hospitals or to universities.

Meanwhile, the migrant student, the provincial aspirant to educational and professional success, remains just as vulnerable to the greed of the private player, who has now gained destructive prominence due to the dysfunction of the public system. The glaring lacunae left by governmental failure have now been eaten up not only by profiteering private institutions of questionable quality, but by the

toxic architecture of the coaching industry, the Kota Factory to most Indians. One doesn't know where the massive fees go, but as the family members of the dead UPSC aspirants now know, it is not being funnelled into the creation of a safe learning and living environment for customers. I'm sure India's many Kota factories have their shares of Jeetu Bhaiyas — the conscientious teacher-mentor from the Netflix show by that name — but I'm also sure their rarity and structural irrelevance make no impact on the landscape of the terrifying mental and physical health of the students stuck in their clutches.

We remember the suicides, as we must. We will never forget S Anitha, the poor Dalit student from Tamil Nadu, whose tragedy bared all that is dark and destructive in India today; The relentless attempt of the juggernaut of the central government to override state authority and dismantle federalism, the oppressive myth of "One Nation, One Exam", the structural violence and exclusion fated for the vulnerable. It took one death to reveal them but the suicides didn't stop.

The suicides stay with us and power protests. But a reality just as tragic greys our sky today. The students who may not take their own lives may just have their lives taken away from them. Death may come either from the strategic neglect of governments or the greed of private players who prey upon the anxiety of millions at the Great Roulette Wheel of seats or jobs. From earth or water. Who knows what else is next?

Majumdar's latest book is Open Intelligence: Education Between Art and Artificial

As a student, I felt invisible to the city's powerful



PRANJYA GROVER

AS A student from Lucknow, I worked towards a dream — a seat at Delhi University. The university is a symbol of possibility for many who couldn't otherwise afford it. Despite the city's reputation, parents nurture their child's dream because of its promise. They eagerly accompany their child to look for a "home away from home". I remember my parents' faces dropping as soon as they entered the clutter and squalor of the Satya Niketan area. For the 17-year-old me, the dirt and congestion didn't matter as much. I had cinched a seat at Jesus and Mary College in the Psychology Department and was over the moon. I had also known that this was all that my family could afford in the South Delhi neighbourhood. All I could imagine was how I could transform this matchbox-sized room into 100 square feet of cool. So I stacked books, put up fairy lights, and filled my walls with posters and keepsakes.

In hindsight, what I was really trying to do was replace the claustrophobia with things that would soften the harshness of returning to a suffocating room with no ventilation or sunlight. It would soften the reality that I was paying upwards of Rs 12,000 in rent (which was about the same as my annual college fees) and sharing a "queen" bed, one tiny toilet, and a small desk, of which the chair collided with the bed the moment you stood up.

My beloved roommate (whose hometown was Kota) and I made the best of the living situation, not because we enjoyed it but because that was our only option. We both took turns falling sick; typhoid was a frequent visitor in the lanes of Satya Niketan. We romanticised the rooms as "cosy". This is the precise vulnerability of a student's life that builders take advantage of. Low-income families don't just pay monetary debts; sometimes, as happened this week in Satya Niketan, the cost is their child's unlivable life.

It has always seemed to me — as a student and now as a citizen — that we are invisible to the city's powerful. Their remarkable capacity and resilience to turn disaster into opportunity work for builders. This is why, when I heard of the building collapse in Satya Niketan, which has already claimed seven lives and injured others, I wasn't surprised. Because the tragedy of a student trapped in rubble, crying for help, is not only a heartbreaking image but also one that speaks of something familiar — a dangerously flawed ecosystem: Of recurrent negligence, collusion of private owners with civic officials at all levels, and the normalcy of damage control that overrides precautionary measures.

I wonder what this tragedy will mean for students who come after me. What it will mean for the students currently residing in that neighbourhood. How do you resume everyday life knowing that the very roof above your head — your supposed home away from home — can collapse any moment? That help is incredibly far, be it their guardians in far-away hometowns or actual on-ground help. At least I have the privilege of distance today. For those who stake their hopes on these systems, the risk, and the price they pay, is their mental and physical health and future.

Satya niketan literally translates to "Home of Truth" — that is a misnomer if there were ever one.

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40 YEARS AGO September 8, 1986



Dead and injured arrive

THE ARRIVAL of the Indian Airlines relief plane at Bombay with 96 passengers and six bodies ended the tragic hijack drama of the Pan Am jumbo at Karachi airport. Bedlam prevailed at the arrival terminal after the Airbus A300 landed. Anxious relatives inquired in vain about passengers who did not figure among those in the plane and whose names were not mentioned in the official list.

PM stands his ground

PRIME MINISTER Rajiv Gandhi said that Pakis-

tan President Gen Ziaul Haq had himself told him in Harare that the Pan Am hijackers spoke in Urdu and Arabic. Gandhi stood by his statement that Pakistan had "badly bungled" in handling the rescue operation of the passengers and crew of the hijacked jetliner.

Reagan's response to Pan Am

THE US administration has said it has not linked the hijacking of Pan Am flight 073 in Karachi "with any specific group or government", but ordered a navy battle group to the central Mediterranean in case President Ronald Reagan should decide to retaliate.

The aircraft carrier USS *John F Kennedy*, which has been in the Spanish port of Benidorm, is expected to sail eastward with escorting warships.

NAM appeals to US, USSR

IN WHAT is being hailed as the most important outcome, leaders of the Non-Aligned Movement have decided at their summit in Harare on a package of measures to help frontline African states in their struggle against apartheid and established a fund under the chairmanship of PM Rajiv Gandhi to undertake suitable projects.